

What Role Should the Public Have in AI Decisions?

Utah Solutions Forum

Delegate Orientation

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Prepared by BLOOM Project based on the [Official Briefing Book](#)

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Your Central Question

You are one of 40 Utahns from Cache, Salt Lake, and Utah Counties, selected by lottery to form a group that reflects the demographics of those three counties. Together, you will consider:

What role should the public have in shaping decisions related to AI technology and infrastructure that affect Utahns' workplaces, education, natural resources, and tax dollar expenditures?

The Opportunity

As delegates, you will have the opportunity to:

- **Review input** from community meetings and participatory polling held over recent months
- **Hear from experts** representing a range of perspectives
- **Consider trade-offs** and real-world constraints
- **Develop potential solutions**

Following the Solutions Forum, Utah Common Ground will support delegates and other interested members of the public in working to secure the group's final recommendations

What Is AI?

- Artificial intelligence refers to **computer systems that perform tasks normally associated with human intelligence**—such as recognizing patterns, generating content, making predictions, or supporting decisions
- **Most systems until 2020 were built for specific tasks, not general ability**
- **Recent generative AI (such as ChatGPT, Claude and Gemini) can create text, images, audio, video, and code.** They can also produce convincing information that is inaccurate or fabricated

A BRIEF HISTORY

1950s–2000s

AI research advanced unevenly and remained specialized

2010s–present

Faster computing, more data, and ChatGPT's 2022 release brought generative AI into everyday use and public debate

Many AI Decisions Are Public Decisions

- AI's impacts depend on how systems are designed, deployed, owned, powered, and regulated
- Some risks can be managed by individuals—for example, by limiting how much personal information they share with an AI tool
- Others affect entire communities and cannot be managed by individuals acting alone
- **Communities have a stake in both the benefits AI creates and the costs and risks it distributes**

For each decision, consider:

- Who benefits?
- Who bears the risks and costs?
- Who decides?
- Who has a voice?

AI's Impact: Jobs and the Economy

Possible benefits

- Assist workers and automate repetitive tasks
- Increase productivity and reduce administrative burdens
- Improve planning, public health, disaster response, and infrastructure management

Risks and uncertainties

- Disrupt jobs and wages, particularly in occupations involving routine cognitive work
- Reconfigure or eliminate jobs, creating difficult transitions for workers and regions
- Distribute productivity gains unevenly—leaving unresolved whether new jobs will emerge quickly enough, who will benefit, and who will be displaced

AI's Impact: Education, Health, & Human Capability

Possible benefits

- Personalized learning, translation, and wider access
- Better diagnostics and faster medical research
- Less administrative work for teachers and clinicians
- Greater independence for people with disabilities

Risks and uncertainties

- Weaker critical thinking if AI substitutes for learning
- Academic integrity concerns
- Effects on literacy and social-emotional learning, especially for children with learning differences
- Compulsive use, isolation, manipulation, or emotional distress

AI's Impact: Safety, Fairness, Privacy, & Information

Possible benefits

- Help public and private institutions identify patterns and assess risks
- Reduce barriers to employment, health care, education, and social participation when systems are designed inclusively
- Improve disaster response and public health monitoring

Risks and uncertainties

- Enable fraud, fake media, and identity deception
- Make misinformation easier to produce at scale
- When trained on flawed data, AI systems can reinforce unfairness in hiring, lending, housing, policing, and health care
- Expand surveillance in ways that may erode privacy and civil liberties
- Concentrate consequential decisions in too few hands

Where Does AI's Energy Demand Comes From?

Individual use is a small share. Most demand comes from building and running models at scale.

YOUR OWN USE

- A single prompt uses about as much electricity as a 10-watt LED bulb running for 90 seconds.
- Using an AI assistant 15 times a day for a year would cost under 50 cents at Utah electricity rates.

WHERE IT ACTUALLY GOES

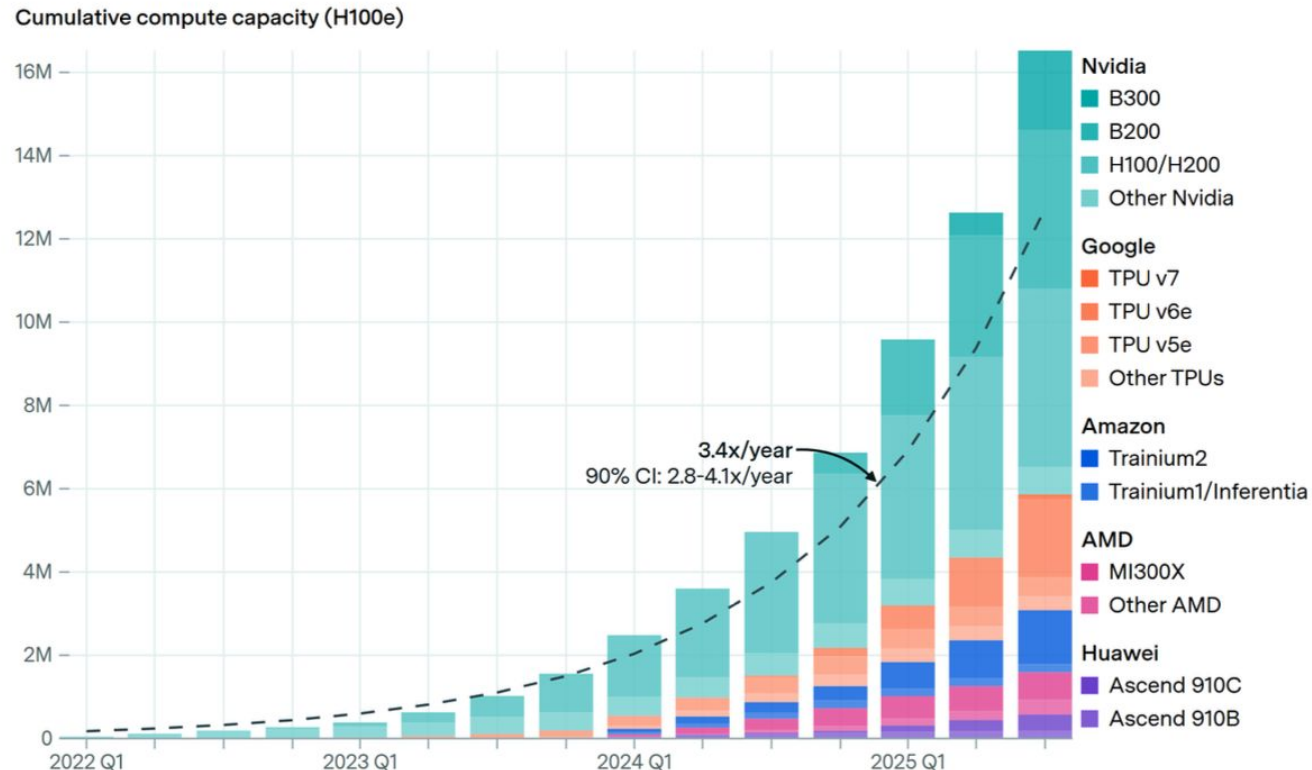
- AI developers and cloud providers use electricity both to build models and to run them for millions of users at once.
- Much of it is invisible: search summaries, social feeds, content moderation, translation, and AI built into everyday business software.

WHAT CHANGED

- Data centers are not new. U.S. data centers used about 4.4% of the nation's electricity in 2023, paid through ordinary utility rates.
- A conventional server rack draws 5–10 kilowatts. A rack built for AI draws 40–80 or more.
- For years efficiency gains offset rising demand. That is no longer the case.

The Scale of AI Computing Is Growing Fast

Global AI computing capacity has roughly doubled every seven months since 2022.



WHAT THIS SHOWS

- Total computing capacity from AI chips has grown roughly 3.3 times per year since 2022.
- NVIDIA accounts for over 60% of it. Google and Amazon make up much of the remainder.
- This is the demand that data centers, electricity, and water are being built to supply.

Who Pays for AI Infrastructure?

Companies finance the buildings initially. Where the costs land over time is unsettled.

HOW IT WORKS NOW

- States and local governments often provide tax incentives or discounted electricity rates.
- That can shift some costs onto other taxpayers and utility customers.

WHAT HAPPENED ELSEWHERE

- Northern Virginia holds the world's largest concentration of data centers.
- Rapid growth in electricity demand there has contributed to rising wholesale power costs and intensified debate over who should pay for new infrastructure.

WHAT IS STILL OPEN

- Analysts expect only about half of announced projects to be operating by 2030.
- If projected demand does not materialize, utilities and regulators must decide who bears the cost of infrastructure already built.
- Utah officials have said developers should bear those costs rather than existing ratepayers.

AI Policy: A Fast-Moving Landscape

GLOBAL

- Countries may develop incompatible approaches to AI governance, creating a fragmented global landscape
 - AI systems and their effects cross borders, so some questions can't be settled by any one jurisdiction acting alone
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UTAH

- Utah combines support for innovation with targeted protections: an AI policy office and regulatory "learning laboratory," disclosure and liability rules, privacy protections, state-agency reporting, and laws addressing data-center water use and harmful synthetic images

FEDERAL

- No comprehensive federal AI law exists; policy is set through executive orders and individual agencies
 - Current priorities emphasize U.S. leadership, innovation, national security, and a single national framework—meaning less state authority to regulate AI. No state law has been preempted so far
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PRIVATE SECTOR

- Company standards are voluntary, and they vary in scope and enforcement
- Advanced chips, computing infrastructure, proprietary data, and the models themselves are concentrated among a small number of organizations, which shapes competition, transparency, user control, and resilience

What Is Public Consultation?

Public consultation brings the knowledge, values, priorities, and experiences of affected people—like you—into government decision-making.

- This process can strengthen decisions and confidence in government
- It may include hearings, public meetings, town halls, comment periods, surveys, deliberative forums, and elections
- It can also require substantial time and resources and may attract primarily highly motivated participants, whose views may not reflect the broader public

Why Public Consultation Matters

Done well, public consultation can create better policy outcomes, increase trust, and lead to decisions more people can live with.

BETTER POLICY

Residents and other affected people bring knowledge, experience, and insight into which trade-offs their communities can accept.

LESS POLARIZED CONVERSATIONS

Structured discussion among residents, community organizations, and businesses helps participants understand one another's needs and identify opportunities to create broader benefits.

BUILDS TRUST IN BOTH DIRECTIONS

Public participation signals that government considers people's judgment worthwhile, and explaining how that input shapes decisions can build trust. Officials, in turn, see that the public can be a valuable partner in addressing hard challenges.

DECISIONS MORE PEOPLE CAN LIVE WITH

A fair process that people can participate in or observe makes an outcome easier to accept, including for those who preferred a different result.

What Good Public Consultation Includes

A clear reason to engage	People know what problem is being addressed, why it matters, and how their input will be used.
Accurate, accessible information	People receive clear, trustworthy information.
Real opportunities to take part	Affected people can participate, with enough time and support to do so effectively.
Genuine listening	Decision-makers weigh input before options close.
Transparency & accountability	The process and the evidence are visible, and decision-makers explain what they chose and why.
Review & improvement	The process is evaluated over time and changed when it is not working.

When Could the Public Have a Role?

Public consultation matters before, during, and after a decision. Reliable information matters throughout.

BEFORE A DECISION

- Receive accurate information about what is proposed and why
- Identify benefits, costs, risks, and alternatives
- Contribute local knowledge and priorities before commitments are made

AS A DECISION IS MADE

- Comment on proposed laws, rules, permits, incentives, or government uses of AI
- Examine trade-offs and help prioritize solutions
- Ask officials to explain their reasoning and how input affected the outcome

AFTER IMPLEMENTATION

- Compare promised benefits and safeguards with actual results
- Seek human review or appeal when government decisions cause harm
- Help decide whether a policy should continue, change, or end

Conclusion

AI is beginning to reshape our economy, environment, and daily lives. What that transformation will mean remains uncertain, and even experts disagree about what the evidence shows.

That uncertainty is precisely why public consultation matters. When residents receive timely, accurate information and have a meaningful opportunity to weigh in, governments can make better decisions and build greater public trust.

Residents bring something no expert or official can provide alone: firsthand knowledge of how these choices affect their communities, which trade-offs they are willing to accept, and which values should guide the path forward.

Thank you for lending your judgment to this process and helping shape what comes next.

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Draper, UT

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